as candidates coming to power in seats without universal suffrage of their constituents.[11]

There was a lengthy preparation for the first announcement of cancellations on 12 October. It occurred somewhat later than expected as the UEC was busy with candidate scrutiny and its contestation (see below) in September. The second announcement, less than two weeks before election day, seemed to occur as an ad hoc response to real security concerns. On 27 October, elections were cancelled for the two townships of Monshu and Kyethi, as well as for eight additional village tracts in neighbouring Tangyan township in Shan State.[12] These cancellations followed the responsible district subcommission's demand to partially cancel elections after fighting had broken out between the Tatmadaw and the Shan State Army-North (SSA-N). The subcommission later argued that they could not "send the ballots" and had genuine concerns about the safety of electoral personnel and materials if elections went ahead.[13] Political spectators disputed the legitimacy of this decision. Representatives of other EAGs understood the escalation of fighting in this area as a consequence of the SSA-N's non-participation in the NCA signing ceremony on 15 October, and the Tatmadaw's attacks — similar to those in Mohnyin township, Kachin State, with "unusual intensity" (TNI 2015, p. 4) — as a punishment for their absence.[14] The SNLD accused the UEC of political motivation, seeing the cancelled constituencies as potentially safe wins for its party. Meanwhile the SNLD's direct political opponent, the SNDP, encouraged and welcomed the UEC's decision to safeguard campaigners' safety and voters' rights, which, from its perspective, were under threat.[15]

While the UEC might have had good reason to cancel elections in most cases, due to past experience few stakeholders trusted the genuineness of their motivations prior to the 2015 elections. The UEC's decisions were also interpreted as synonymous with decisions of the Tatmadaw and other state institutions, while in reality they might not have been related. The collective positive experience of the 2015 elections, and the generally well-trusted results, may lead to increased confidence in this particular government institution in the future. More clarity about UEC law section 10f and election laws section 50 would help to avoid the potential for politically motivated contrasting interpretations of partial election cancellations. Currently, these suspensions are a more complex phenomenon related to different reasoning, motivations, and opinions than a simple 'security' explanation might suggest.